"WE'VE WARNED PLATFORMS OF PROSECUTION FOR DEEPFAKES"

As the menace of deepfakes mounts across India, Rajeev Chandrasekhar, *the Union Minister of State for Electronics, Information Technology and of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship*, spoke to *Group Editorial Director* Raj Chengappa about the Modi government's concerns, the actions it has taken and modifications in the law that are on the anvil. Excerpts:



Photographs by CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Q In a recent interaction with journalists, Prime Minister Narendra Modi warned of the threat of deepfakes. What is the extent of this threat and why should we be worried?

We in the government have been aware for a while of the underlying rise of a disturbing phenomenon, that is, broadly, the ability to weaponise misinformation, disinformation and false information with the objective of creating unrest. We have made it the government's mission to ensure that our policies are all aimed at creating a safe, trusted and accountable internet. Cybercrimes have, in a sense, turned on its head the earlier narrative that internet and technology are all about the good. When you fast-forward and extrapolate all those problems and then overlay them with the power of the once-in-a-lifetime invention of artificial intelligence (AI), then you have a perfect storm in the making that is going to be extremely disruptive and worrying. This phenomenon of deepfakes, which is really a marriage of AI and the misinformation industry, is certainly something that all of us should be worried about because it is very potent for individuals, for societies, for communities and countries. We are thankful to the honourable prime minister for raising this issue and creating national awareness about it. We have attempted over the past two years to create rules and regulations against misinformation.

Q. The 2024 general election is upon us. What is the danger deepfakes can inflict on political parties?

Look, misinformation itself poses a big challenge to the democratic process of a free and open election. Deepfakes are a very, very dangerous way of misleading people, who are increasingly consuming only on video. In the backdrop of the polarisation that politics has created and a lot of people indulging in the politics of lies, imagine what that can do. It is really like a matchbox to sort of ignite passions and create disorder that will be extremely difficult for people to predict and understand. So, weaponisation of misinformation, which used to be a problem, has taken on a different dimension and scale with deepfakes.